

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4**PART A Group Interaction**

Below is an extract from an online newspaper:

Celebrity Justice: Does Punishment Fit the Crime?

If you're driving around New York City and see a street sweeper who looks an awful lot like the famous international singer Boy George, don't worry, you're not going crazy.

The singer was found guilty of drug possession and will start his five days of community service on Monday.

"No special treatment," said a Times Square sanitation worker. "A broom, a dustpan, and work to be done."

From drugs to drink driving charges, the list of criminal celebrities is long. But many believe their punishments don't always match the crime.

"Celebrities have a huge advantage over the average person," said Harvey Levin, managing editor of the entertainment news website TMZ.com. "Juries are comprised of television watchers, moviegoers, people who listen to music, and they tend to show a lot of goodwill towards celebrities."

However, many A-listers do have good records when it comes to bouncing back from a crime. Actress Winona Ryder was arrested on shoplifting charges and accused of stealing US\$5,500 worth of designer clothes and accessories at a famous department store. In 2002, she was sentenced to 480 hours of community service, US\$3,700 in fines, US\$6,355 in repayment to the department store and ordered to attend psychological and drug counseling.

Two years later, a judge reduced her crimes to misdemeanors (lesser charges) after she completed her 480 hours of community service. She has since gone on to star in more than 20 films.

As members of the Liberal Studies Society, your group is discussing celebrity and crime. You may want to talk about:

- whether you agree with the punishments given to celebrities
- why famous people who commit a crime are sometimes treated differently
- whether you would still support a celebrity even after he or she has committed a crime
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you have a favourite pop star?
2. Which famous person is a good role model?
3. Is having an idol a good or bad thing for teenagers?
4. Why do some people worship celebrities?
5. What would you say to your friends if they wanted to be a celebrity?
6. Should celebrities be given stricter penalties if they break the law?
7. Do you think celebrities should be well-behaved all the time?
8. Does fame make a celebrity a better person?